

OpenClaw Vocabulary Guide

Every term you'll hear in the course, explained in one or two sentences. Keep this open during your first few lessons.

THE BASICS

Gateway	The main program that runs everything. It connects your chat apps to the AI model and keeps your agent alive. You start it once and leave it running. <i>Think of it as the engine of the whole system.</i>
Agent	Your personal AI assistant. It has a name, a personality, memory, and skills. When you message it on Telegram, you're talking to your agent.
Channel	Any chat app your agent is connected to. Telegram, WhatsApp, Slack, Discord, iMessage, Signal — each one is a channel.
Skill	A plain-text file that teaches your agent how to do something specific. No code needed — just instructions written in English.
SOUL .md	A text file that defines your agent's personality, tone of voice, and behaviour rules.
User .md	A text file that tells your agent who you are — your name, preferences, and context. Read before every conversation.
Memory	Your agent's ability to remember things across conversations. Permanent rules and facts stay between sessions.
Session	A single conversation thread. Type /new in Telegram to start a fresh one. The agent forgets the chat but keeps permanent memory.

Don't memorise any of this. Every term is explained again when it comes up in the course. This is just your quick reference.

More Terms You'll Meet Along the Way

MODELS & COST

AI Model	The brain that powers your agent. Claude, GPT, Gemini, Kimi — these are all AI models. OpenClaw lets you pick which one to use.
API Key	A secret code that connects your agent to an AI provider. You create one on the provider's website and add it to your setup.
Tokens	The units AI models use to measure text. Roughly 1 token = 3/4 of a word. You pay based on token usage.
Smart Routing	A setup where cheap models handle simple tasks and expensive ones only kick in for hard work. Cuts costs 60–70%.
Heartbeat	Wakes your agent up at regular intervals to check for tasks or run schedules. Useful but watch API costs.
Cron Job	A task your agent runs on a schedule — every morning, every hour, every Monday. Set it once, runs automatically.
Sub-Agent	A temporary helper your main agent creates for a specific task. Works in its own session, sends back a summary.

SECURITY & INFRASTRUCTURE

Prompt Injection	When someone hides instructions inside an email or web page hoping your agent will follow them. Teach your agent to treat external content as data.
Pairing	Connecting your Telegram (or other app) to your agent for the first time. You approve it so only you can talk to your agent.
Gateway Token	A password for your agent's web dashboard. You need it to log in from a browser.
Dedicated Account	A separate email created just for your agent. Never connect your personal Gmail — always use a dedicated one.
VPS	Virtual Private Server. A small cloud computer you rent for a few dollars a month. Your agent runs on it 24/7.
Docker	Packages your agent into a container. On Hostinger, OpenClaw runs inside Docker. Managed through Docker Manager.
Tailscale	A free VPN that creates a private network between your devices. Access your dashboard securely from anywhere.
Dashboard	The web interface for your agent's settings, conversations, and status. Also called the Control UI.

OpenClaw Masterclass — Vocabulary Guide — by Damian Danelczyk